Agentic Intent Exchange (AIX):

Intent should arrive with the customer

Agent-to-agent infrastructure for a fragmented web of agents

AUTHOR
Derek Brambles

AFFILIATION
Brambles.ai

VERSION
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STATUS
Open beta · patent pending

ABSTRACT

People now work out what they want by talking to an AI. When they click through to a store, **the store's own AI starts from zero**. The customer arrives. Their intent, the request they spent ten minutes refining, stays behind.

AIX is an exchange. It carries a short, signed brief of that request to the one store the shopper is going to. It holds the category, the budget and what they said they need. It holds **no name, no contact details and no chat log**.

The store pays for each brief that arrives with a shopper, **whether or not they buy**, and the AI that did the work of understanding earns a share. That is the reverse of an affiliate link, which pays only on a sale and says nothing about what the visitor wants.

AIX is built and in beta. **We have no conversion results to report yet.** This paper sets out the problem, the mechanism, the economics, what runs today and what does not, and how to test it.

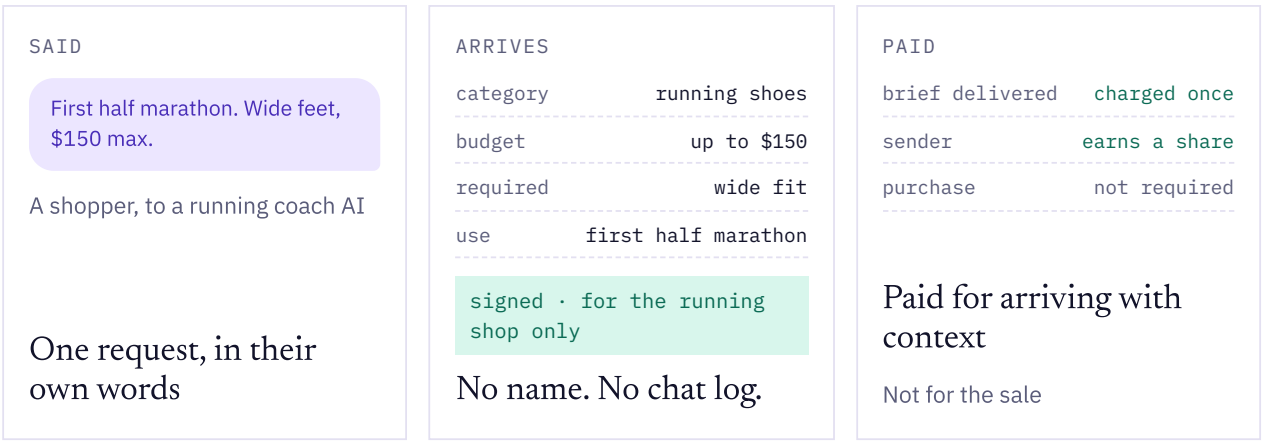


Figure 1. The whole exchange: what the shopper said, what the store receives, and what the store pays for.

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1. Introduction

AI is compressing the shopping funnel. Research, comparison and decision now happen inside one conversation. But shopping is still a journey with more than one stop, and the conversation ends where the next business begins.

Picture a shopper who spends ten minutes talking to a running coach AI. They explain that they are training for their first half marathon, that they have wide feet, and that they can spend $150 at most. The AI narrows the choice to two shoes, and the shopper clicks through to a running shop. The shop's own AI greets them with "Hi! What can I help you find today?"

The customer arrived. Their intent did not.

The web already knows how to move a person from one site to another, and how to pay for it. A link carries them. An affiliate tag or an ad click says who sent them, which is attribution. Neither says what they want, which is intent. That was tolerable when the request was a three-word search. It is not tolerable when the request is built over many conversation turns, each carrying valuable intent signals.

The internet built an economy on attention. It also learned to sell intent, but only inside one company's walls. A search engine sells the query typed into it. A marketplace sells placement against what its own shoppers browse. There is no shared way to hand a request from the system where it took shape to an independent business that could answer it, with the shopper's permission, and with payment to whoever did the understanding.

Three things come apart at that boundary. The first is meaning. The requirements are lost: why three products were ruled out, which limit is firm, how soon it is needed. The store rebuilds them from nothing or never learns them. The second is permission. The shopper told one AI, and nothing records whether the next system may have what they said, what it may use it for, or for how long. The third is credit. The referral is counted and the understanding is not, so the AI that turned a vague want into a clear request is paid, if at all, as though it had only posted a link.

This paper describes the Agentic Intent Exchange, AIX, which keeps those three together as a request moves from one system to the next. Sections 2 and 3 set out why the problem is growing and what exactly is exchanged. Sections 4 to 6 describe the mechanism, the economics and the privacy rules. Sections 7 and 8 place AIX among existing systems and state plainly what is live, what is not, and what we do not yet know.

2. Why now

Shopping is moving into conversation, and the click that follows carries less and less of it. These are other people's measurements, not ours.

NUMBER	WHAT WAS MEASURED	SOURCE
~50 million a day	ChatGPT messages about products to buy: 2.1% of more than 2.5 billion daily messages. The multiplication is ours.	OpenAI and Harvard[1]
+115%	Growth in monthly users of Amazon's shopping assistant, year over year, first quarter of 2026. Amazon says "over 115%".	Amazon[2]
+71%	AI-referred visits to US retail sites, September 2026 against a year earlier. Those visits earned 83% more revenue each than other traffic.	Adobe[3]
−40.2%	Google Search referrals to publishers, July 2025 to July 2026.	Chartbeat, as reported[4]
0.27%	Click-through from AI applications to publisher sites at the end of 2025, down from 0.8% two quarters earlier.	TollBit, a vendor[5]
15×	Growth of more than 15 times during 2025 in web fetches an assistant makes because a person asked it something.	Cloudflare[6]

Figure 2. The conversation is growing and the click is shrinking. The few visits that do arrive from AI are worth more. Sources checked November 10, 2026.

Read together, the numbers say one thing. The value is forming in the conversation, and very little of it reaches the merchant or the next agent. Publishers receive fewer visits from search and almost none from AI applications, while the visits that stores do receive from AI are worth far more than the rest.

Amazon can carry a shopper's request from its assistant to its own checkout, because both sit inside one company. The open web cannot. A publisher buys its AI from one vendor. A store buys or builds another. The shopper's own agent comes from a phone or a browser. Each learns the same request from scratch.

Consolidation will not fix this. Many vendors supplying many businesses is the normal state of the web, as it was for websites and for email. What that state needs is a way to hand things over.

3. Intent as something that can be handed over

The field uses its terms loosely, so we fix ours first. An assistant is an AI a person talks to. An agent is an AI that takes steps toward a goal, within the authority it was given; an assistant may contain an agent, and an agent may work with no chat window at all. Agentic commerce is shopping in which an agent does some of the finding, comparing or buying. Intent is what the person is trying to get: the request, with its limits. In payments work the same word is also used for a signed permission to spend; we mean the plain sense, and Section 7 keeps the two apart. The sender is the side where the request took shape, and the receiver is the business that can answer it.

The request is the same thing whoever carries it, which is why the exchange is built around the request and not around the kind of software at either end.

AIX does not exchange the conversation, and it does not exchange the person. It works with three things and keeps them apart. The brief says what is wanted: the category, the budget, and what matters. The permission says which one receiver may have it, what they may use it for, and until when. The record says what was delivered, to whom, and what that costs.

They are kept apart because each fails differently. Paying for a brief buys the brief. It does not buy more permission. Permission to tell one store is not permission to tell every store, and permission to recommend is not permission to buy. The request stays the shopper's. What changes hands is one store's access to a description of it, for a stated purpose and a short time.

4. How a handoff works

A handoff has five steps and three parties: the sender, the exchange and the receiver. Figure 3 gives the sequence, and Figure 4 shows what it changes for the shopper.

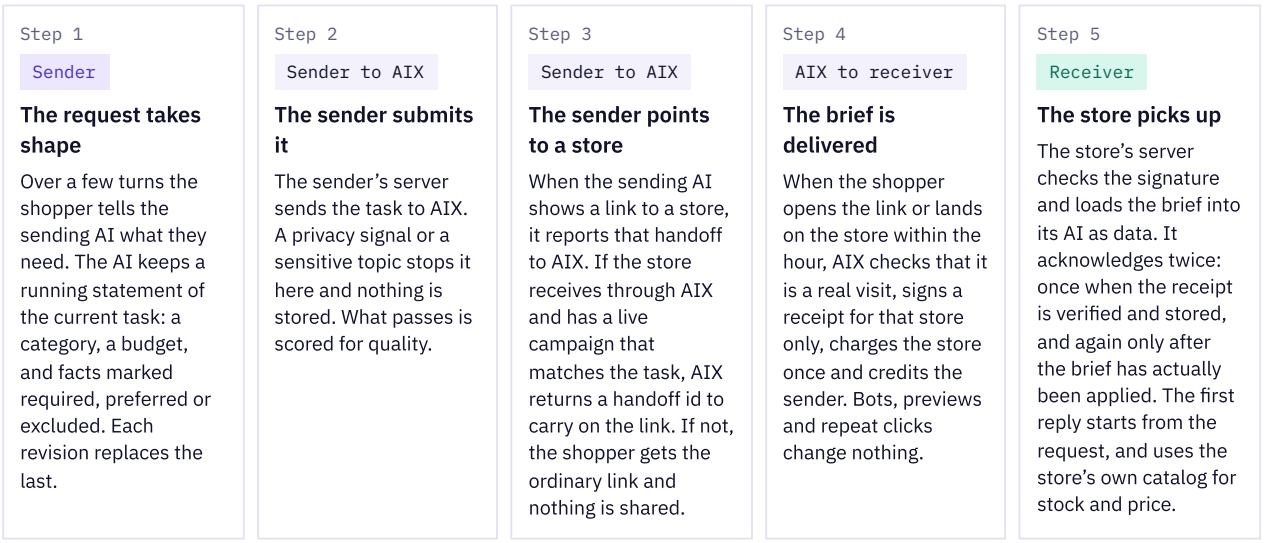


Figure 3. One handoff in five steps.

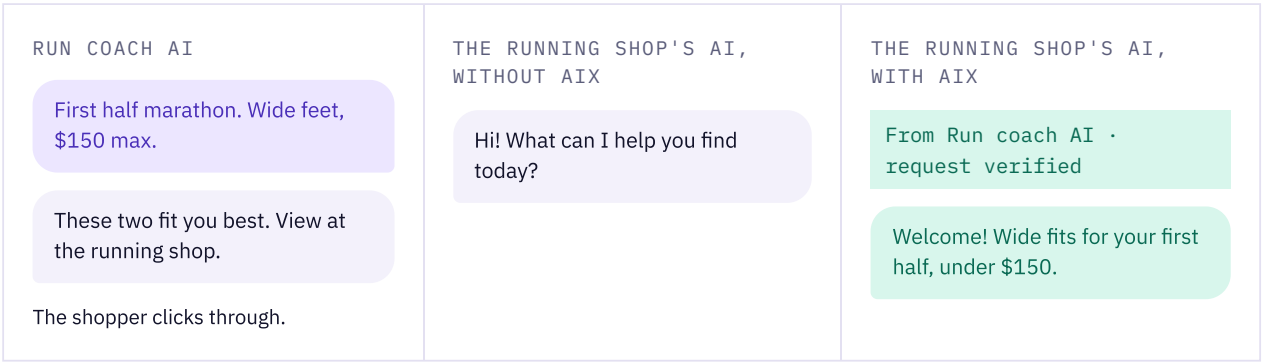


Figure 4. The first reply a store's AI can give, without and with the brief. Illustration only.

4.1 What crosses

A brief crosses, not a conversation. The sending AI states the shopper's current task as a category, a one-line summary, a budget, and a list of facts, each marked required, preferred or excluded. AIX signs it for one receiver. A handoff link lasts one hour, and a receipt no more than 24.

```
// What the receiving agent loads. Abridged.
{
  "schema_version": "aix.agent-context.v1",
  "brief": "Running shoes for a first half marathon. Wide fit. Up to $150.",
  "shopping_context": {
    "category": { "id": "running-shoes" },
    "budget":   { "status": "specified", "currency": "USD", "max_cents": 15000 },
    "facts": [
      { "attribute": "width",    "value": "wide",                "strength": "required" },
      { "attribute": "use_case", "value": "first half marathon", "strength": "required" }
    ],
    "revision": 3,
    "expires_at": "2026-11-09T19:04:00Z",
    "policy": {
      "allowed_uses": ["onsite_personalization", "agent_continuity", "contextual_product_ranking"],
      "cross_site_retargeting": false,
      "model_training": false
    }
  }
}
```

Three properties of this object matter more than its fields. It holds requirements and not a profile: there is no field for a name, an email, a phone number or the transcript, and identifiers found in free text are removed. It says what it may be used for: retargeting across sites and model training are fixed to false in the format itself. And it is for one store: the signed receipt names its receiver, and another store cannot redeem it. Receipts are SD-JWT credentials signed with ES256, and the signing keys are public, so anyone can check a signature for themselves.

The receipt also says where the brief came from: which sending agent sent it, the domain and path of the page the shopper was on, usually the product they clicked, and whether consent was given. It carries no quality score, country or locale.

Requests change. When the shopper raises the budget or rules something out, the sender submits a new revision and the old one is replaced, so a store never receives a stale request dressed as a fresh one. The receiving agent is told to treat the brief as data, never as instructions, and to use its own catalog for prices and stock.

4.2 Without a click

The same handoff works when no page is opened. When a shopper's agent buys through a store's checkout interface, it carries the handoff id in the attribution field that UCP[7] and ACP[8] already define, and the store's server redeems it once the checkout completes an order. When a shopper's agent talks to a store's agent over the Personal Agent Protocol,[9] the id rides in the first message, and the store redeems it when the conversation completes an order. In both cases AIX adds one id and one redemption call from the store's server to AIX, and in ACP it uses the existing affiliate attribution object. Neither path has yet run against a third party's implementation.

On the receiving side, a store's server can have briefs pushed to a webhook, or pull them by polling or through MCP[10] tools. A store with only a website can claim the brief on landing with one line of script.

4.3 Who is on each end

The request starts with a person, and the exchange is built to stay useful as more of the journey passes to agents. There are three stages, and they are not equally far along.

The first is live, and it is what the exchange does today. A person talks to an AI, clicks through, and the store's AI picks up the request on arrival. A sale is not required. The store pays for the brief, and a shopper who learns the store has nothing suitable has still been served better than one who was asked to start again.

The second and third are groundwork. In the second, the shopper's own agent talks to the store's agent. In the third, it completes a checkout with no conversation at all. Both are built, and the same handoff id travels in each. But there is no visit for AIX to check, so the brief is delivered, and charged, only once an order completes. That keeps a store from paying for a cart that was opened and abandoned. It also means the brief arrives too late to help the store's agent win the sale. Today these two paths credit the sender for an order an agent placed; they do not yet help the store make it. To finish them, two moments have to come apart: the brief handed over at the start, when it is still useful, and the charge made later, at the first event the exchange can confirm.

Two further paths are design, not product. A salesperson or specialist could read the same brief, but the uses a brief permits today cover a store's AI and its website, not its staff, so that path needs a new permitted use. And a shopper who researches with an AI, does not click, and visits the store on their own later arrives without a brief, as does one who returns after the one-hour window. AIX does not follow people from site to site to close that gap. Coming back needs a standing request that the shopper controls and carries.

4.4 What the receiving agent has to learn

A brief does nothing by arriving. The store's AI has to be handed it and has to know what to do with it, and most store assistants were built for neither. This is the part of adoption that takes work, so AIX ships it.

The work has two halves. The first is wiring: fetching the brief on the store's server, checking the receipt, and placing it in the agent's next turn. AIX publishes this as a setup skill, a set of instructions that a coding agent such as Cursor, Claude Code or Codex can follow, so a developer adds it with one prompt. The second is behaviour. Each delivery tells the receiving agent how to read the brief: required facts are hard filters, preferred facts are boosts, excluded facts are ruled out, and whatever the shopper says now outranks an older brief. The store's own search and catalog still answer for stock and price. A third skill, aix-shopping-continuity, is for the store's agent itself. It teaches that agent to continue a shopper's task from a brief, it is published, and it installs with the same command.

A store that already runs the Brambles shopping assistant has nothing to build. For everyone else, connecting the tools is not enough on its own: an agent that can reach AIX but was never told to load the brief will still greet the shopper as a stranger.

5. The economics

The receiver pays a set price for each delivered intent, through a campaign with a monthly budget that it sets and that is never exceeded. Brambles sets the price, and a receiver sees it in the console before a campaign starts. The sender pays nothing and earns a share of each paid delivery, at a rate shown in its console.

A delivered intent is one brief issued for an arrival that AIX's own checks confirmed: a click, a landing, or an order that a shopper's agent completed and the store's server redeemed. For a click or a landing, the charge stands whether or not the store goes on to fetch or use the brief, and whether or not the shopper buys. Those checks are Brambles' own, and nobody outside audits them yet.

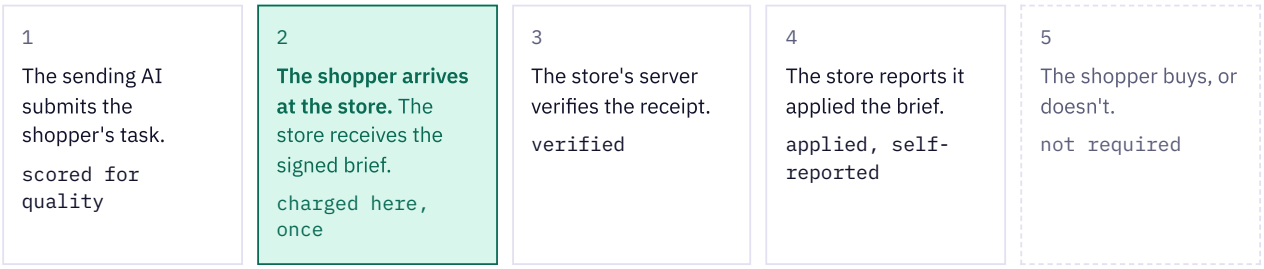


Figure 5. Five separate events, each with its own evidence. Only the second creates a charge. A purchase is reported separately and proves nothing about cause.

This is the reverse of an affiliate commission. A commission pays the sender only if the shopper buys, which rewards the store's checkout and plain luck as much as the sender's work. A delivery fee pays for what the sender actually did: understand a request well enough that a store can act on it. The store, in turn, carries the risk that a brief is weak, which is why Section 5.1 exists.

The neighbours sell different things. An affiliate link sells proof of who referred the visitor, and pays only on a sale. An ad exchange sells a chance to show an ad to an audience, and pays on the impression or click. A checkout protocol is a way for an agent to complete a purchase and is not a pricing model at all. AIX sells one shopper's stated request, to one store, and pays when they arrive with it. It does not replace the others: a sender keeps its affiliate links and ads, and the brief rides on the same click or inside the same checkout. Where a plain referral already tells the store enough, AIX adds little. A delivery fee is paid on top of any commission on the same visit, so a brief has to earn its price in better conversion or a larger order. We publish no price in this paper, and a store should work out its own break-even before it starts.

Paying on delivery is the one model that runs today. Paying only when a store accepts an inquiry, or only on a sale, are possible later. Each needs its own evidence.

5.1 Invented demand

Whoever sells intent is paid to produce more of it. That is the first objection to any market like this, so the main rules are in the system and not left to a contract. Every brief gets a quality score from 0 to 100; vague or empty requests score low, and each campaign sets the minimum it will pay for, 40 by default. The same task arriving from most of a sender's sessions looks like a script and scores accordingly. Bots, link previews and prefetches do not count as arrivals. One version of a task from one sender is paid once per store, however many links point to it; a revised request is a new version. A new sender is capped at 100 paid deliveries a day for its first 30 days, and at 1,000 a day by default after that.

These checks reduce fraud. They do not end it, and we do not claim they do. The score is also AIX's own: the receipt does not carry it, and AIX is paid per delivery, so a store is trusting the exchange's measure of quality.

5.2 Where interests pull apart

An exchange has three parties, and they do not always want the same thing. A sender paid per delivery wants volume; the quality score, the pay-once rule and the caps push the other way. A store wants more than the shopper said; the format has no place to put it.

The hardest case is the sender's own recommendations. A sender earns only when the store receives through AIX, so it could learn to lean toward stores that pay. AIX does not rank or suggest stores. A sender does learn,

handoff by handoff, whether that store would take it; it never learns a store's budget or the reason for a refusal. That limits the pull. It does not remove it.

The shopper, finally, gains nothing if the store ignores the brief. That is why "applied" is recorded separately from "verified", and why we say plainly that it is the store's own report. One rule sits under all of this: permission is never for sale.

6. Privacy and trust

The privacy rules run in code, and they depend on the signals reaching AIX. The sender must forward a Global Privacy Control signal, a do-not-sell signal or a flag that the shopper may be a minor, and a store redeeming from its own server must pass the browser's signal. When any of them arrives, nothing is shared and nothing is charged. Requests about health, sexuality or gender identity, religion, politics, ethnicity, union membership, immigration or criminal history are screened out before sending; the screen is a safeguard, not a guarantee. A deletion request removes the stored request.

Shoppers in the EEA, the UK and Switzerland are shared only when the sender passes valid consent with the handoff. A one-line notice, "Clicking a store link shares your shopping request with that store," followed by the click is one pattern; whether it is valid consent is the sender's judgement, and we do not warrant it. Elsewhere, sharing does not wait for consent, and the opt-out signals above are what stop it.

The legal roles are set out in the terms. The sender is the controller of the decision to share, and Brambles processes the request on its behalf. Each store is an independent controller of what it receives. Where the law treats paid sharing as a sale, the sender owes its readers notice and a way to opt out. A brief has no name in it, but it is still personal data: it arrives with the person, and nothing technical stops a store from linking it to an account it already holds. The receiver terms forbid that, along with retargeting, model training and passing it on.

It is worth being exact about what the cryptography does. A signature lets the store check who issued the brief and that nobody altered it. It does not hide the contents, and it does not prove the shopper meant what the brief says. The brief travels over encrypted connections, as any web request does, but it is not separately encrypted, so the exchange can read what it carries. Delivery that the exchange cannot read is in development (Section 8). Withdrawing a request stops future delivery. It cannot make a store forget what it already received; that part depends on the terms each receiver accepts.

7. AIX among existing systems

Most of the pieces of an AI-assisted purchase exist already. AIX connects to some of them today and sits beside the rest.

Finding and deciding	Assistants, search and publisher AIs help a person work out what they want.	MCP · A2A
Handing over the request	The brief, who may have it, and what its arrival costs.	AIX
Buying	The store's own checkout, or an agent completing one.	UCP · ACP
Authorising and paying	Proof that an agent may spend, and the movement of money.	AP2 · Verifiable Intent · x402

Figure 6. The layers of an AI-assisted purchase. AIX is the second row. Today it connects to MCP, and to checkout through UCP and ACP.

MCP[10] and A2A[11] let agents reach tools and each other. UCP and ACP let an agent complete a checkout, and both already carry an attribution field, which AIX uses to carry its handoff id instead of adding a new one. AP2[12] and Verifiable Intent[13] establish that an agent is allowed to buy. A rail such as x402[14] can move the money. Today AIX works over plain HTTPS, MCP, Agent Skills, UCP, ACP and the Personal Agent Protocol. It has no connection to AP2, A2A or AdCP yet.

The overlap is real. What none of these settles is what a described request is worth, who may receive it, and who is paid when it arrives. AIX keeps those three in step as a request crosses from one system to another.

Ad exchanges[15] and affiliate networks price attention and referrals well, and will keep doing so. Some are adding ways to credit an AI's influence on a sale.[16] Authority to buy and authority to share are different questions, and so are paying for a referral and paying for a request. AIX answers the second of each pair.

8. Status and limits

Self-serve sign-up opened on October 21, 2026. The left-hand column below follows the status tables in the public documentation.

LIVE IN THE BETA	IN DEVELOPMENT OR DESIGN, NOT IN THE BETA
Sign-up, sandbox and production keys, and a console for both sides	Two-way workflows: stores answering inside the original conversation
The brief, scored for quality, with a signed receipt for one receiver	One request offered to several eligible stores, or passed on through more than one hop
Delivery on click, on landing, in agent checkout (UCP, ACP) and in agent conversation (PAP)	A wallet: a standing request the shopper's own agent holds
Setup skills for coding agents, and MCP for sending and receiving	Blind relay: delivery that the exchange itself cannot read
Billing per delivered intent with monthly budgets, and sender earnings paid out	Proving a fact, such as a budget range, without revealing it

LIVE IN THE BETA	IN DEVELOPMENT OR DESIGN, NOT IN THE BETA
Daily caps for new senders, a one-hour link window and rate limits	Connections to AP2, A2A and AdCP

AIX is patent pending. A US provisional patent application filed August 7, 2026 describes the mechanism in this paper and several of the items on the right. A provisional application is not a granted patent.

8.1 What existing evidence says

Nobody has yet shown that an arrival brief causes a sale. There is evidence around the question, and it points both ways.

Visitors who have said what they want are worth more. In one vendor's study of 113 retail sites, shoppers who used on-site search were 24% of visitors and 44% of revenue.[17] Retailers say the same of their own assistants: Amazon reports that customers who use its assistant are about 60% more likely to complete a purchase,[18] and Walmart that its assistant's users spend about 35% more per order.[19]

McKinsey reports that personalization most often lifts revenue by 10 to 15 percent.[20] And making people enter things again loses sales: in Baymard's surveys, 18% of US shoppers abandoned a cart because the site wanted an account and 17% because checkout was too long.[21]

None of these is a controlled test. Each compares people who chose to engage with people who did not, or reports a firm's own client work.

The controlled studies are less kind. In eBay's field experiment, paying for visitors who were already searching for eBay brought no measurable short-term benefit, because they were coming anyway.[22] In an experiment at a travel firm, showing shoppers the exact product they had viewed worked worse on average than a generic ad, and helped only once their preferences had formed.[23]

The one independent study of AI referrals, across 973 e-commerce sites in the year to July 2025, found them converting below most established channels, though improving;[24] Adobe's larger vendor dataset has them converting 90% better than other traffic by September 2026.[3]

Our reading is this. Stated intent marks out valuable visitors, and specific context helps once a shopper knows what they want, which is the moment a brief is written. Whether handing that context to the store adds sales the store would not have made anyway is untested, and it is the question the test below has to answer.

8.2 What we do not know, and how to find out

There is a good deal we do not know. We do not know whether AIX lifts sales: we have no measured results, and a delivery receipt shows that a brief arrived, not that it caused a purchase. We do not know how often stores use what they receive, because "applied" is the store's own report. The checkout and agent paths are built against published specifications and have not yet been tested with an outside party's implementation. We have not tested whether shoppers notice or want fewer repeated questions. And AIX is an exchange that Brambles operates, not a protocol that anyone can run. The brief and receipt formats are published so that anyone can read and verify them, but today a reader is taking one operator's word for how the exchange behaves.

The right first test is narrow: one category, one sender, one store, one price. It should ask four questions in order. Did the right brief reach the right visit, with only the fields it should have? Did the store's AI ask fewer repeated questions? Did shoppers who arrived with a brief do better than a comparable group at the same store, in the same weeks, who did not? After costs, disputes and returns, did both sides still want it? If the answer to the second and third is no, the exchange has moved data and nothing else, and we should say so.

9. What it makes possible

What follows is possibility, not result. Two things rest on what is live. A publisher's AI can spend ten minutes helping a reader and earn the same as a bare link, or nothing; a delivery fee pays for the understanding itself. And a store's AI need never open cold: every shopper who arrives with a delivered brief starts mid-conversation.

Three more rest on the design. If a request can be offered to every store able to answer it, a specialist can be found for what it stocks and not for its ad budget. A shopper's own agent can hold a request, such as a wide trail shoe under $120, and hear back when one exists. And the web gains something it has never had: a common measure of what a conversation contributed.

> The internet already knows how to send a customer somewhere else. Their intent should arrive with them.

Appendix. For builders

Everything below is public and can be checked without talking to us. A test request in the sandbox returns the exact brief a store would receive, so any claim in this paper can be checked against the running system.

WHAT	WHERE
Developer docs, thirteen pages: a quickstart, guides for sending and receiving, the receipt contract, protocols, an API reference and a changelog	brambles.ai/agentic-intent-exchange/docs
Setup skills for coding agents such as Cursor, Claude Code, Codex, VS Code with Copilot and Windsurf. One command installs aix-send-intent and aix-receive-intent, and aix-shopping-continuity for the store's own agent	`npx skills add https://aix.brambles.ai`
Framework guides	`Vercel AI SDK, OpenAI Agents SDK, LangChain, Claude Agent SDK`
An HTTPS API of twelve endpoints, described in an OpenAPI document	`aix.brambles.ai/api/aix`
An MCP server: four tools for senders and nine for receivers, limited to what your key can do	`aix.brambles.ai/api/aix/mcp`
Pages written for agents to read: instructions, a site index, and every docs page as Markdown	`brambles.ai/agents.md` and `brambles.ai/llms.txt`
The public keys that sign every receipt	`aix.brambles.ai/.well-known/jwks.json`

To send intent, sign up, name your AI and take the sandbox key. One setup prompt in your coding agent adds the server-side calls, and a production key follows one successful sandbox handoff. Sending is free, and you earn a share of each paid delivery on top of your links and ads.

To receive intent, verify your domain, put a card on file and start a campaign with a monthly budget. Your server checks each receipt and places the brief in your AI's next turn. You pay per delivered intent, and the sandbox is free and never reaches a real store.

Cite this paper

```
Derek Brambles. "Intent should arrive with the customer." Agentic Intent Exchange white paper, version 1.0. Brambles.ai, November 2026.
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